

Impact Low · Difficulty Medium · Misuse risk It fails when you treat a signal as proof and declare the person's preference — "

THE MOVE

Signal + tentative label + choice + respectful follow-through. -> When you mentioned the new role, you had a lot more detail. Is that the thread to stay with? -> You lit up a bit when travel came up. Want to talk about that, or keep this ?

START HERE

Notice the one topic that had more energy, name it softly, and hand over the choice: "You seemed more interested when we got to [topic] — want to stay there, or keep moving?"

SAY THIS

Quick openers	"More energy on [topic]?"
Social / catch-up	"You seemed more animated when you mentioned [topic]. Want to stay there for a bit?"
Professional / meetings	"The [topic] part seems to have more substance. Should we focus there?"
Choice framing	"We can stay with [topic], or I can answer the original question directly. Which is more useful?"
Digital / text	"Your last reply had a lot more detail around [topic]. Want to unpack that?"
High-pressure & bou...	"I do not want to overread this. Is [topic] the key issue, or should I stay with the original point?"

AVOID

- They have stated a boundary or asked to stop
- There is an urgent agenda, safety issue, or legal, medical, or HR process
- You are tempted to use the signal to push a sale, flirtation, or confession

REMEMBER

Give the steering wheel back.